YEAR 7–8 HPE · VICTORIAN CURRICULUM 2.0

Swim & Water Safety

A 5-lesson unit on the knowledge, skills and decisions that prevent drowning in Victorian waters.

5 LESSONS × 50

WORKBOOK · POSTERS · SCE

CLASSROOM-BA

UNIT MAP

Five lessons, one question

What knowledge, skills and decisions could prevent most Victorian drownings — including among people our age?

LESSON

01

Victoria's drowning crisis — why it matters to you

VC2HP8P09
VC2HP8P1

LESSON

02

Beach flags, signals & rip current survival

VC2HP8P1

LESSON

03

Emergency response — DRS ABCD & rescue skills

VC2HP8P1

LESSON

04

Hazards, decisions, inland waterways & alcohol

VC2HP8P08
VC2HP8P1

LESSON

05

Personal action plan & communication campaign

VC2HP8P09
VC2HP8P1

LESSON 1 · 50 MIN · WORKBO

01

Victoria's drowning crisis — why it matters to you

VC2HP8P0 VC2HP8P1 Classroo

What knowledge, skills and decisions could prevent most Victorian drowning deaths — including among people our age?

THE UNIT'S BIG QUESTION — RETURN TO IT I

The numbers behind one Victorian summer

TOTAL FATAL DROWNINGS

52

Lives lost in Victorian waters across the year.

AGED 15–24

about 1 in 8

Victims were in or near our school age group.

MALE VICTIMS

46

Of 52 — 38 male, 14 female.

IN PUBLIC POOLS

0

Zero deaths in public swimming pools — first time since 2019–20.

1 IN 8 VICTIMS

13 %

of Victorian drownings in 2024–25 were people aged 15 to 24. That's the age group most of us will be in within five years.

Life Saving Victoria · lsv.com.au/re

WHERE IT HAPPENS

Inland waterways kill more Victorians than beaches

Rivers, dams & lakes

Cold, fast-moving and full of unseen hazards — submerged logs, sudden depth changes, hidden currents. Most Victorian drownings are at **unpatrolled inland sites**, often within an hour of someone's home.

Think Yarra, Goulburn, Murray; Lake Eildon, Lake Eppalock; farm dams across regional Victoria.

Beaches & pools

Drownings at the beach almost all happen **away from the flags** — on unpatrolled stretches, at dawn or dusk, or when the patrol has packed up for the season.

Pool drownings cluster around backyard pools and toddlers — but Year 7–8 students need to know it too, especially when supervising siblings.

Source · LSV Victorian Drowning Report 2024–25

WHY OUR AGE GROUP

Four reasons teenagers face higher risk near water

01 Overconfidence in swimming ability

Pool laps don't prepare you for a cold river or a rip. Most young victims are described by friends as "a good swimmer".

02 Peer pressure to swim somewhere unsafe

Groups push individuals to jump, swim, or stay in when they wouldn't on their own. "Everyone else is doing it" is the most common factor in young-person drownings.

03 Risk-taking and impulse decisions

Jumping from rocks, diving into murky water, swimming further than planned — decisions made in seconds with consequences that last a lifetime.

04 No-one watching, no-one trained

Friends in the water can't rescue friends in the water. Unpatrolled means no lifeguard, no equipment, no quick response.

THE SINGLE MOST IMPORTANT ACTION

Swim at a patrolled location, between the red and yellow flags.

In 2024–25, Victoria recorded zero drowning deaths in public swimming pools — the first time since 2019–20. But 25% of deaths happened in home environments, where no lifeguard can reach.

Source · LSV Victorian Drowning Report 2

LESSON 1 · EXIT TICKET · 5 MIN

One fact that surprised you. One question you still have.

Write both in your workbook before you leave. Be honest — the question is what we'll come back to in Lesson 2.

LESSON 2 · 50 MIN · WORKB(

02

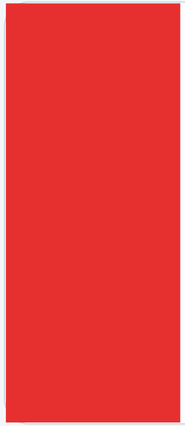
Beach flags, signals & rip current survival

VC2HP8P1

Classroo

READING THE BEACH

The six flags every Australian beach-goer must know



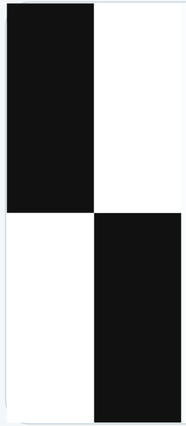
Red & Yellow

Swim here. Patrolled swimming area.



Solid Red

Dangerous conditions. Stay out unless very experienced.



Black & White Quartered

Surfcraft only. No swimmers — surfers and watercraft.

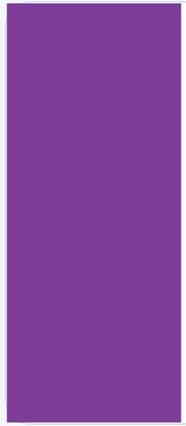
Yellow + Black Ball

Swimming OK. No surfboards or watercraft.



Orange Windsock

Offshore winds. No inflatables.

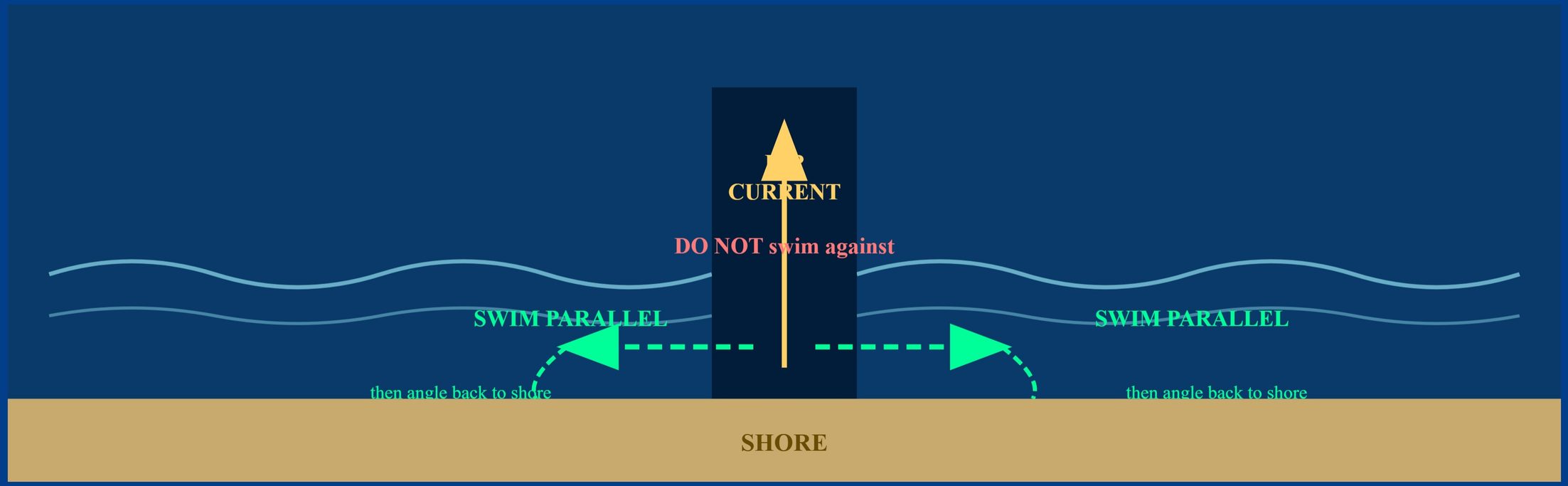


Purple

Marine stingers or dangerous marine life.

THE NUMBER-ONE BEACH HAZARD

What a rip current actually looks like



1
Stay calm. Don't panic.

2
Float — conserve energy.

3
Swim parallel to shore.

4
Angle back to the beach.

5
If tired, signal for help.

IF CAUGHT IN A RIP

Five steps. In order. Every time.

01

Stay calm

Panic burns the energy you need. A rip won't pull you under — it pulls you out.

02

Float on your back

Let the rip carry you. It usually weakens 30–100 metres offshore. Conserve everything you've got.

03

Swim parallel to the shore

Across the current, not against it. Aim for the breaking waves on either side — that's where the calmer water is.

04

Angle back to shore

Once out of the rip, use the broken waves to ride back in. Don't swim straight back through the rip.

05

Signal for help

One arm raised, held high. Keep floating. A lifeguard's job is to come to you.

SCENARIO · WORKBOOK ACTIVITY 2.2

Liam's day at the beach

📍 SCENARIO

Liam is 14. He's at the beach with friends on a hot summer day. They go to an unpatrolled beach. Liam swims out past where the others are standing and feels himself being pulled away from shore quickly. He panics and tries to sprint-swim directly back to the beach, but is getting more tired. His friends notice and don't know what to do.

In pairs: identify two mistakes Liam or his friends made, and explain what they should have done differently.

BEFORE YOU GO · TOOLS TO USE

Find your three closest patrolled beaches

Use BeachSafe (beachsafe.org.au or the app) at home tonight. Write your three closest patrolled beaches into your workbook before the next lesson.

A

Patrol dates and times

Most Victorian beaches are patrolled weekends Nov–Apr, daily over school holidays. Outside those windows, the beach is unpatrolled — even if the flags are still standing.

B

Live conditions

Wind, swell, water temperature, rip risk. Check before you leave home, not when you arrive.

C

Hazards specific to that beach

Some beaches have submerged rocks, strong tidal flow, or known rip locations. The app tells you.

LESSON 2 · EXIT TICKET · 5 MIN

Recite the five rip-current survival steps from memory.

Notes closed. Workbook open to Section 2. Write them in order. If you miss one, that's tomorrow's revision.

LESSON 3 · 50 MIN · WORKBO

03

Emergency response — DRS ABCD & rescue skills

VC2HP8P1 | Classroo | Practica

THE RULE THAT KEEPS RESCUERS ALIVE

Throw, don't go.

Untrained rescuers who enter the water often become the second victim.

If you can throw or reach the casualty without entering the water — do that.

USE WHATEVER FLOATS

A

Rope or long towel

B

Kickboard or bodyboard

C

Esky lid · empty bottle

D

Inflatable · life ring

RESCUE HIERARCHY · RLSSA

Five rescue options — safest to most dangerous

01

Talk

Shout calm instructions. Tell the person to float, to look at you, to swim across to safety. Sometimes that's enough.

02

Reach

From the bank or pool edge — extend a pole, branch, paddle or towel. Lie down so you don't get pulled in.

03

Throw

A floating object on a rope is ideal — a kickboard, life ring, esky lid. Aim past the person so the rope crosses their chest.

04

Row

Use a boat, kayak or paddleboard — only if you're confident on it. Approach into the wind so you don't drift past them.

05

Go

Enter the water only as a **last resort**, only with a flotation aid, only if trained. Most students should never reach this step.

THE EMERGENCY ACTION PLAN

DRS ABCD — seven steps, in order



Used by every Australian first-aid organisation. The order matters — checking **Danger** before **Response** stops you becoming the next casualty.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO · WORKBOOK ACTIVITY 3.1

DRS ABCD — what you do at each step

D	**Danger**	Check for hazards to you, bystanders, and the casualty. Electricity, traffic, more water entering — don't approach until it's safe.
R	**Response**	Tap shoulder, ask loudly: "Can you hear me? Open your eyes." If no response, treat as unconscious.
S	**Send for help**	Call 000 (triple zero). Put on speakerphone. Don't hang up. Send someone else to flag down emergency services.
A	**Airway**	Tilt head back, lift chin. Clear water, sand, vomit. Check the airway is open before checking breathing.
B	**Breathing**	Look, listen, feel for up to 10 seconds. If not breathing normally — start CPR.
C	**CPR**	30 chest compressions, then 2 rescue breaths. Repeat until help arrives or the casualty starts breathing.
D	**Defibrillation**	If an AED is available, turn it on and follow the voice prompts. Don't dry the chest if wet from water — the AED tells you.

CPR RHYTHM

30 + 2

COMPRESSI

BREATI

Repeat until help arrives. About 100–120 beats per minute — the rhythm of "Stayin' Alive".

CALL

000

01 Ask for **Police, Fire, or Ambulance** . Water emergency = Ambulance.

02 Give the **exact location** . Address, road name, nearest landmark, GPS pin if you have it.

03 Describe the casualty: **conscious or not, breathing or not** , age, how long they were in the water.

04 Stay on the line. Put it on **speaker** . Do not hang up until the operator tells you to.

05 Send someone to **flag down the ambulance** at the road or carpark.

SCENARIO · WORKBOOK ACTIVITY 3.2

The river rope swing

📍 SCENARIO

It's a hot February day. You're at a popular but **unpatrolled** rope swing over a river. A 16-year-old you don't know swings out, lets go, and hits the water awkwardly. He sinks and doesn't resurface. One of his friends jumps in to help — and also starts struggling. You're on the bank. You have a **towel, a rope on the swing, and your phone**.

In pairs · 6 minutes: (1) What is your FIRST action and why? (2) Why is the friend jumping in a problem? (3) If you pull him to the bank not breathing, list the DRS ABCD steps in order.

LESSON 3 · EXIT TICKET · 5 MIN

Write DRS ABCD from memory — and one action for each letter.

Notes closed. Seven letters, seven actions. If you've got them all, teach the person next to you.

LESSON 4 · 50 MIN · WORKBOOK

04

Hazards, decisions, inland waterways & alcohol

VC2HP8P0

VC2HP8P1

Three Victorian environments, three risk profiles

Patrolled Beach

E.G. TORQUAY · MORNINGTON · LORNE

Rip currents away from the flags
Offshore winds & inflatables
Sunburn, dehydration, fatigue
Marine stingers (uncommon in Vic)

OVERALL RISK **MEDIUM**

River, Dam or Lake

E.G. YARRA · LAKE EILDON · MURRAY

Cold water shock — even in summer
Hidden currents & submerged logs
Murky water — can't see depth
No lifeguards, no equipment

OVERALL RISK **HIGH**

Pool — backyard or public

BACKYARD · SCHOOL · PUBLIC AQUATIC CENTRE

Slip hazards on wet surfaces
Diving into shallow water
Unsupervised toddlers (backyards)
Faulty pool fencing

OVERALL RISK **MEDIUM**

Five rules. Before you enter any water.

Rule 01

Read signs

Check warnings, flags and notices before you go anywhere near the water.

Rule 02

Enter feet first

Never dive into unknown water. Hidden rocks and shallow edges cause spinal injuries.

Rule 03

Stay in depth

Only swim where you can stand comfortably — unless you're a confident, experienced swimmer.

Rule 04

Swim with a friend

Drowning is silent. Someone watching means someone can call for help.

Rule 05

Signal for help

One arm raised. Float. Conserve energy. Keep signalling until help arrives.

The 1 · 10 · 1 rule

1

MINUTE

Cold shock

Involuntary gasp reflex. If your head is under, you breathe in water. This is when most cold-water drownings happen.

10

MINUTES

Useful movement

Your arms and legs progressively lose strength and coordination. Use this window to self-rescue or signal.

1

HOUR

Hypothermia

Core body temperature drops dangerously. Unconsciousness follows. Even strong swimmers don't survive past this point without rescue.

Source · Royal Life Saving Australia · National Drowning Report

Three lines that work when friends push you in

WHAT THEY SAY

"Come on, it's fine, everyone's jumping. Don't be soft."

WHAT YOU SAY · STRATEGY: NAME THE RISK

"Nah, I'm not jumping into water I haven't seen the bottom of. Last summer a kid broke his neck doing that."

WHAT THEY SAY

"There's no flags but the surf looks fine. Let's just swim."

WHAT YOU SAY · STRATEGY: OFFER AN ALTERNATIVE

"The patrolled beach is 10 minutes that way. I'll drive / walk. Anyone keen?"

WHAT THEY SAY

"He's been drinking but he's fine. He always swims at parties."

WHAT YOU SAY · STRATEGY: PUT YOURSELF IN THE WAY

"Mate, give me five minutes before you go in. Eat something. I'll come down with you after."

WORKBOOK ACTIVITY 5.3

Why alcohol and water don't mix

01

Impaired judgement

Alcohol convinces drinkers they're stronger swimmers than they are. Distances look shorter. Currents feel slower. Decisions get worse.

02

Slowed reactions, weakened muscles

When something goes wrong — a wave knocks you, a foot slips — alcohol makes you slower to react and physically weaker. You lose the seconds you need.

03

Faster heat loss

Alcohol dilates blood vessels at the skin. You lose body heat faster, and cold-water shock and hypothermia set in sooner.

04

Riskier behaviour all round

More likely to jump, more likely to swim alone, more likely to ignore signs. Alcohol is a factor in around 1 in 3 adult Victorian drownings.

What you think you know could kill you

MYTH *"If other people are jumping there, it must be safe."*

FACT Water depth changes **daily** — tides, drought, sandbank movement. Someone who jumped safely yesterday could hit the bottom today.

MYTH *"Clear water means deep water."*

FACT Clarity tells you nothing about depth. **Dangerously shallow water can be crystal clear** — especially in rivers and beach channels.

MYTH *"Only bad swimmers get hurt diving."*

FACT A cervical spine fracture happens **on impact** — before swimming ability is relevant. Strong swimmers suffer the same injuries.

MYTH *"Diving injuries are rare — it won't happen to me."*

FACT Unsafe diving accounts for around **10% of spinal cord injuries and 20% of quadriplegia cases** in Australia. Highest incidence: ages 10–14.

Sources · Royal Life Saving Australia · AIHW · Royal Perth Hospital spinal injury study

LESSON 4 · EXIT TICKET · 5 MIN

Recite the five SwimSafe rules from memory.

Then write down the one that's most important for you personally — and why.

LESSON 5 · 50 MIN · WORKBOOK SECTI

05

Personal action plan & communication campaign

VC2HP8P0

VC2HP8P1

Assesse

ACTIVITY 6.1 · PERSONAL ACTION PLAN

Plan a real Victorian water activity — for your summer

01 · Where

Which Victorian water environment will you be in?

Be specific: a named beach, river, dam, pool, or paddle location. Not "the coast".

02 · What

What are you actually going to do there?

Swim, paddle, surf, supervise siblings, jetty fishing — each has different hazards.

03 · Hazards

List three specific hazards for that location.

Use Lesson 4's hazard map. Cold water? Rips? Murky water? Submerged objects?

04 · Strategies

Which SwimSafe rules apply, and how?

Pick three of the five rules and write what you'll actually do — not just the rule name.

05 · Emergency

If something goes wrong — what's your plan?

Who's calling 000? Where's the nearest patrolled beach or hospital? What's in your bag for a throw rescue?

06 · Equipment

What are you bringing?

Phone charged? Sun protection? PFD if paddling? Rope/floating object in the car?

ACTIVITY 6.2 · COMMUNICATION CAMPAIGN · PICK ONE

Design water-safety content for a real audience

A

SOCIAL MEI

For teenagers 13–17

Instagram or TikTok carousel — 1 to 3 slides. Must include one Victorian statistic with its source URL and a clear call to action.

B

LETTE

For a Year 5 student

~200 words explaining the three most important things they need to know about Victorian water safety before summer.

C ★

COMMUNITY FACTS

For someone new to Australia

Multilingual or plain-English factsheet on beach flags and Victorian waterway dangers. Five key points and two statistics.

ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

What a great campaign looks like

- [ ] The **audience** is clear and the language fits them — a Year 5 letter doesn't read like a TikTok caption.
- [ ] At least **one accurate Victorian statistic** appears in the message — with the source URL cited.
- [ ] There's a clear **call to action** — what should the audience do, today, after seeing this?
- [ ] The safety message is **accurate** — uses correct vocabulary (rip, parallel, DRS ABCD, throw don't go, patrolled).
- [ ] Sources are **credible** — LSV, RLSSA, Paddle Australia, Parks Victoria, BeachSafe. Not social media posts or random blogs.
- [ ] Personal thinking is visible — not just a copy of the poster pack. The teacher should feel **you wrote this**.

WHERE YOUR FACTS COME FROM

Use these — and cite the URL

Life Saving Victoria

`lsv.com.au · lsv.com.au/research/victorian-drowning-reports`

Use for · Victorian drowning data, SwimSafe rules, patrolled beaches

BeachSafe

`beachsafe.org.au`

Use for · Finding your nearest patrolled beach & live conditions

Royal Life Saving Australia

`royallifesaving.com.au`

Use for · National data, inland waterway safety, CPR & rescue

Paddle Australia

`paddle.org.au`

Use for · Cold water shock, PFDs, kayak/SUP safety

Parks Victoria

`parks.vic.gov.au`

Use for · River, lake and reservoir hazards in Vic parks

St John Ambulance Victoria

`stjohnvic.com.au · 000 for emergencies`

Use for · First aid, DRS ABCD, CPR technique

WHOLE UNIT ON ONE SLIDE

Five lessons. One thing each.

Lesson 01

Why water safety matters here

52 Victorian drownings in 2024–25

About 1 in 8 victims aged 15–24

Zero deaths in public pools

Teenage risk = peer pressure + overconfidence

Lesson 02

Reading the beach

Six Australian beach flags

Rip currents pull out, not under

Stay calm · float · parallel · angle in · signal

BeachSafe app before you leave home

Lesson 03

Emergency response

Throw, don't go

Hierarchy: talk · reach · throw · row · go

DRS ABCD — seven steps in order

CPR: 30 compressions + 2 breaths

Lesson 04

Hazards & decisions

Inland waterways = highest risk in Vic

The 5 SwimSafe rules

Cold water shock: 1 · 10 · 1

Alcohol + water = no

Lesson 05

Plan & campaign

Personal action plan for your summer

Campaign for a real audience

One stat · one URL · one call to action

Credible sources only

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Statistics: Life Saving Victoria, Victorian Drowning Report 2024–25. Deck updated September 2026.

Data sources cited in this deck — retain these citations if you adapt it:

- Life Saving Victoria. (2025). Victorian Drowning Report 2024–25. Life Saving Victoria: Melbourne.
- Royal Life Saving Australia (2026). National Drowning Report 2026. RLSSA: Sydney.
- Surf Life Saving Australia (2026). Summer Coastal Drowning Report 2025/26. SLSA: Sydney.

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